Luxury

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/61864015.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra)

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by Storm_Rao

Summary

A kiss might heal the world, but a wounded soul has a long way to come - the first night after The End of She-Ra

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

The bed was too soft. She was far too used to the pallets and bunks of war. This soft mattress and all these pillows seemed like a mockery to someone so indoctrinated into the hardships of life.

Catra rolled again, trying to find a spot to get comfortable in. She felt stupid for agreeing to this. Sparkles – Glimmer – had insisted they come back to Brightmoon after… whatever the hell had happened today. Adora had wanted to do little more than stagger to a familiar spot and fall over. That green junk had damn near killed her, she had earned her rest.

But now, trapped in this mountain of softness, Catra felt like she was going to suffocate. She could feel the cold sweat running down her back. Any amount of lying said it was only the cloying heat of the softness. She finally fought her way free to cool, crisp air.

Adora hadn't moved since she'd hit the mattress. Her face was tense and drawn. Catra hesitated, wanting to touch that soft pink cheek and do something, anything, to chase that anguish away. Her fingers hovered, trembling, before Catra pulled them away. They'd kissed, they'd whispered to each other how much they meant… but self-doubt still gnawed at her. After everything, after so many years of horror, did either of them know what it meant to love? Could she even let herself trust that Shadow Weaver hadn't planted something deep inside that would grow and poison that feeling over time? She already didn't feel that she deserved Adora, and this grand room with its stupid softness did nothing to help. Adora was soft, this place was soft. She was not.

Catra realized her claws were unsheathed. Not to rend or hurt, but to focus on. They were hard and sharp, but not cruel. Every injury they'd ever inflicted. That was her, she was the tool of it, not the claws that had drawn the blood.

She'd liked it too, seeing someone react to her, to scream, to cry. It proved that she was…

Powerful?

It made her feel unclean again. She hated to bathe, but right now she felt she could scrub in a bath for hours without removing that feeling. The dirt was inside her, in her soul…

"Mra."

The sound made her ears flick, then flatten as the soft voice echoed into her mind. She hadn't even tried to describe Melog's voice to the others. They couldn't hear it, maybe they didn't want to. She knew she didn't want them to either, as the cat-creature revealed her secrets to a woman who tried to hide them from herself.

[*You hurt*]

It was hard to deny someone who literally read your emotions, though Catra was quickly learning to focus out of them. She tried a deep calming breath, trying to stuff away that feeling of

inadequacy. Melog padded over, mewling softly. The blue glow of their mane made the world feel insubstantial.

"I'm fine. I just can't sleep."

She lied to herself, like she always did. Her fingers sought her friends' ears, tickling and soothing until the other lost interest in anything but the pets. Soon she coaxed her shapeshifting companion back to the cushions the confused guards had dragged into Adora's room.

Oh yes, how could she forget. This wasn't *their* room, it was Adora's room. This was Adora's place, right by these glossy *princesses* in their *castles* with their god-damned *soft beds*

She was shaking. Catra fell against the wall with a bare shoulder, hugging herself, trembling. She didn't even remember leaving the bedroom, let alone walking this bare hallway. Somewhere in the distance her sharp ears could pick up the dull clink of metal and the steady breathing of guards at their posts.

Her stomach dropped, then knotted. She was still a prisoner! They were here to keep her from going to far! She should have never trusted that stupid sparkly so-and-so.

Her breathing became shallow and rapid as her pupils shrunk to dots. It didn't matter, nothing mattered. She was a failure who was only alive because she wasn't worth killing. She wasn't worth

loving, either. Adora was a sentimental idiot who mistook anger for love. She was so stupid too, that she thought anything about Catra could be worth salvaging in the mess of a person she'd become.

More time passed. The feeling didn't go away, but her breathing slowed. She could claw her way back up the stone wall until she was on her feet. There was no way she could stay here, not with these soft people and their good feelings and their fake smiles. They would nod and play nice, but it was all because Adora, beautiful, idiotic, entrancing, stupid Adora said so. The moment she realized that she would always be better than her, Catra would be abandoned again.

"*Of course I came.*"

The words echoed in her skull. Catra clutched it, pressing her ears against her head. Yes, Adora had come, she'd always come, until she hadn't. Until she'd entered the whispering woods, found that stupid sword, and cut her old life free of her, of everything. Even Horde Prime could tell her that, without ever meeting her. Catra was just a toy, to be used and thrown aside.

She'd staggered further. A cool wind tugged at her tail. She was only wearing the dull grey underclothes, Adora's underclothes. They were too tight on her chest and too loose on her ass, not to mention that her tail had to stick out uncomfortably against the edge. Adora had said something about a "tailor", was that someone who made things for people with tails? They certainly had a lot of people around here that might need that. Or maybe she'd been saying it was a "tall order". She'd been so sleepy when

Catra had tried to ask where she'd gotten these non-horde horde things.

She was standing on a balcony. Her claws dug into the metal as she stared out over the sleeping world. The world seemed so calm here. Maybe that was part of the problem. In the Fright Zone there had always been clanging and hissing in the walls, always some patrol shift changing. In their bunkroom at least there'd always been whatever the heck had been going on with Kyle. Even when he slept he made the most stupid whimpering noises.

The wind picked up, dragging more heavily at her. The chill brought the shivers on more forcefully, but Catra refused to move. She knew she deserved this. She didn't want luxury, she wanted to suffer, for all she had done, for the wrongs she'd committed. She wanted to feel the pain to know that anything else wasn't a lie.

Or maybe… maybe she wanted to feel nothing. If she just left, found a quiet spot and stayed away from anyone, maybe the hurt inside would go away.

The air stilled. Moisture dropped onto her hands. Irritated Catra looked up. There were no clouds. Startled, she touched her cheeks.

Tears.

No, she couldn’t be crying. She wasn’t allowed to cry. She didn’t *deserve* to cry.

The hollow feeling in her stomach blossomed out. She leaned over the railing as she retched into the open air. Nothing came up. Too many years of bad food after good had trained her not to ever let go of a meal. That was it, the hard life of the Fright Zone, it had made her into this…

This mess.

She caught her breath and turned, sinking down against the railing, the tears flowing more freely.

Maybe she should just stay here, not call out when that idiot awoke and called for her. She deserved better, no matter what she said about loving her. The cold air made it clear, Catra had to make sure she cut her out, to get clear before that stupid, hurt look came up, and she started doubting herself all over again. Then she could run, there’d be millions of places where she could just hide, and never have to trouble anyone again…

~

She was moving. The heavy warmth under her cheek wasn’t one she knew, the scent was all wrong. Catra lashed out with her claws and was rewarded with a sharp yelp and the scent of blood.

It was a tiny warm thrill before the person also dropped her to slap a hand over the cut.

"What the heck!"

She blinked, confused, up at the person above her. It was the archery boy, the thinky guy, the princess's beau. Or her *Bow*.

Well she was in trouble now. Despite her determination to get out of here, her ears went back as she tried to prepare herself for the imminent pain and humiliation before she was tossed out. He'd at least let her say goodbye, right? No! Wait! She didn't want to say that!

She tried to duck her head, the confusion running rampant over her face despite her best attempt to control it. Had Adora broken her that much?

"Sorry, I should have guessed you wouldn't like being carried."

Despite the cut, despite the angry smell, his tone was so calm. He dabbed his hand against the gashes and checked it, they weren't deep and the bleeding was already slowing.

"You just looked-"

Weak? Failed? Stupid? Catra felt the hate welling up. How dare he see her in this state.

"Cold, probably uncomfortable."

"I'm used to uncomfortable."

She didn't want to say the words, she didn't want to use that tone. But she opened her mouth and that poison just leapt out. She met his eyes, trying to back it up, stubborn, powerful, *scared*.

He caught her gaze and held it. There was something in his expression. It wasn't like reading Adora, that open-booked, goody-two-shoes idiot. Here she saw subtlety and nuance. Someone used to hiding, used to diplomacy. She saw a man who'd had the harsher side of life, and still…

"Are you alright?"

The words threw her. Catra opened her mouth a few times as she tried to find a response. Was she alright? Were there any words that could even describe what she felt in this moment. His dark eyes never left her mismatched ones. She shrank back, for a moment seeing them shine neon green.

She didn't realize the movement was not just in her head. The expression changed. He hunkered down, his voice quieting, like he

was talking to a frightened animal… or a child. She tried to find the anger again, and was ashamed to realize more tears were escaping.

"I didn't mean to scare you."

"I'm not scared!"

That look again, quiet, evaluating. She felt her breathing quicken, felt the panic rising. He was judging her, he could see all her unworthy. He was Adora's friend now, he was going to tell her! Even though she deserved it, she couldn't bear it being because someone else had said it.

"Please don't tell Adora!"

Please? Since when had she said please? She was powerful, independent, proud, stubborn,

Alone

"Catra…"

She could hear it, he was going to. She couldn't even feel the shivers, or the rocking.

“I’ll tell her myself, I know I’m not… just, please, let me tell her?”

“Tell her… What?”

Confusion, she could see that at least, even as the world seemed to shatter around her. There were more people coming. Everyone could see her coming apart. They could all see her. All the clones, Horde Prime’s eyes everywhere. She was never alone, even by herself. She could never be alone again, she could never be free.

“Hey! Listen to me!”

He had her shoulders, he was shaking her.

“You’re, uhm, what was it, you’re, here?”

He sounded like he was reciting something. He must be an illusion. How else could he not know what to say. Her claws slipped out. She could make it stop. Just one quick cut and the clone that was disguised as a person would fall away. Just one, quick-

Her wrist was caught. Someone was holding her. She flailed, trying to tear herself free of the other clone. She would gouge their eyes out. They’d bleed and their blood would never go into

that pool. She could send them to drown in their own blood that would never nurture another-

"Catra, it's me!"

He was pretending to be Adora again. Pretending and she couldn't think beyond it. He knew just how to bring her into worst self, just by pretending she might be allowed, for one moment, to be with the woman she loved, just for an instant.

"Adora, do you need-?"

"No, please, go, I've got her, it's ok. It really is Bow. Can you get Glimmer?"

That was madness, why would the illusion think she'd ever want to see Sparkles again? Even if they were together on the ship. Maybe it was another ploy to get information out of them?!

Fingers, oh how she hated the way he touched her. Those lingering strokes, those squeezes, those possessive grips. She felt a scream bubbling up inside, and gasped, half-choking to keep it down.

The fingers didn't grip. They moved to her temples. They wandered through her hair. Someone was petting her, and

speaking, softly, gently. She tried to hear the words that seemed far too far away.

"I'm here Catra. You're in Brightmoon, you're not in the ship. Horde Prime is dead. I'm here, you're safe. I'm here Catra, I'm here, with you."

Over and over again.

Soon her breathing had slowed, matching the rythym of the words. The fingers on her temples moved behind her ears, scratching at that one spot that always made her melt.

"Adora?"

Sparkles… Glimmer, she should really try and call her by her real name…

"Thanks for coming, I didn't think-"

"It's ok. Bow said you wanted me?"

"Can you teleport us back to our room? I don't think I can carry her…"

The attack, the… the poison? The green dripping through the woman she loved, stealing her life away, drop by drop, and her willing to let it go to save them all.

"No teleports!"

The words came out in a rushed gasp. The fingers moved to the nape of her neck, stroking more gently.

"She said something, I didn't hear. Catra? What was that?"

"No teleports, I can walk. I can, I just-"

She gasped hard, wheezing as her eyes came open. There was that stupid, sweet face looking in on her, with that expression that looked like someone had woken her up from a deep sleep. She even had the sallow bags under her eyes, like…

…*like she nearly died for you*

Glimmer was peeking in too, and some other people that she couldn't focus on. She couldn't even think where she was.

“She’s coming around. She said something about teleporting.”

The arms holding her moved, lifting her up more. More air flowed into her lungs as Catra gasped again. A soft thumb ran over her cheek, those dumb blue eyes overflowing with concern. Catra felt her ears shift, perking, flattening, going sideways. She wasn’t in control. Her whole body felt like a lead weight.

“No teleports.”

Confusion, the blue eyes flickered wide, then peered at Glimmer. The glittery idiot shrugged helplessly.

“I don’t know if she means it.”

Anger sent a pulse through those deadened muscles. She tried to push away the arms, only to find her limbs operating like noodles. Was that a laugh? She tried glaring at the incoherent shapes beyond glitter-brigade. Adora gave her that stupid half-smile, uncertain. Didn’t she trust her?

No. She’d ruined her trust, remember?

Her breathing shallowed again, becoming sharp and painful. The arms wrapped more tightly around her.

“I’m here Catra.”

She was upright now, her knees tucked under her. Her tail was twitching madly against the muscles imprisoning it against her captor. She nearly unsheathed her claws again.

“Can someone help us walk?”

Hands, she tried to slap them away, but every time she tried it was like trying to hit smoke. They were gone by the time she moved her hands. The only ones that didn’t go were the ones around her shoulders, one that slid over her spine and into her armpit. Someone warm was pressed into her, half leaning on her as much as she was on them. How did she have four knees, and why were two of them pale as a damn piece of paper?

“Ok, one step as a time.”

One of those knees moved. Her own cocked in response. The cold stone jarred her feet, causing a tiny hiss of pain.

“That’s it.”

The other paper-knee moved. Another step, less pain this time. Another, another. She was really getting the hang of it.

“Are you sure you’re going to make it back, you look like death warmed up.”

“I’m sure… it’s not that far.”

Catra moved her head a little, trying to see the faces around them. No eyes glowed back at her, no skeletal hands reached out to correct her. Someone was warm against her side.

One step at a time the pair staggered back to the room she’d abandoned earlier. Adora stared at the bed, feeling exhausted just seeing it.

“Just drag the blankets off, we’ll sleep on the ground.”

Around them guards, helped by their queen, made a passable pallet on the floor. Adora pushed them both just a little further to slump into it, breathing like the short corridor was a marathon. Glimmer made sure the blanket was drawing over them before she left in a short shower of sparkles.

Catra squirmed, feeling the heavy bricks under her hip, even through the blanket. The cover barely took the chill of the night off, but someone was there with her, giving her warmth.

It was all the luxury she needed to be asleep again in moments.

End Notes

I found the show leaving me in a melancholic mood after it ended. Finding that one of the writers MIGHT have written something to put here too, I wanted to make sure I got down how I think Catra is dealing with things like "mattresses" and "food"

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!